CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

# LAND SURVEYOR IN THE AI ERA

Every building, road and property line starts with somebody standing in a field saying: exactly here.

★ **TL;DR — Around $75K a year, on a 2–4 year path of degree or experience plus a state license — the licensed surveyor's stamp is legally required on boundary work. The catch: the license is a multi-year gauntlet, and the field years come first.** ★

## THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

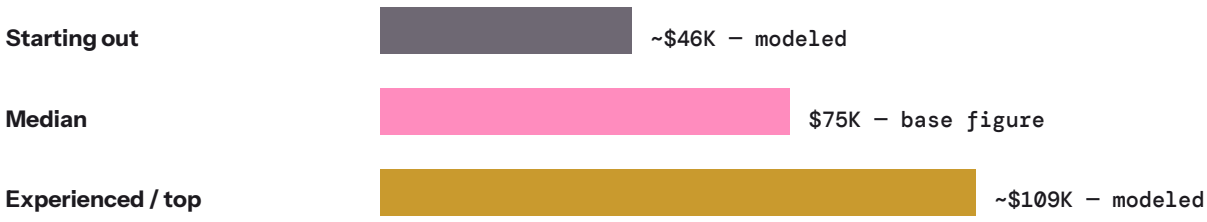
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$75K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- Construction cannot start, and property cannot cleanly change hands, without survey work.
- The licensed stamp is protected by state law — licensed surveyors sign what technicians cannot.
- Technology keeps shrinking crews, which raises the value of the licensed person responsible for the work.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

## THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS




The Career Glitch base figure for Land Surveyor is a ~$75K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

## WHAT DOES A LAND SURVEYOR ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Measure land with total stations, GPS/GNSS rovers, levels and drone data
- ✓ Research deeds, plats and historical records to resolve boundary questions
- ✓ Produce maps, plats and legal descriptions that get recorded and relied on
- ✓ Set construction stakes so buildings land exactly where the plans say

Think: part outdoorsman, part detective, part lawyer with a tripod — you decide where the line legally is.

## WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

| THE ROBOT | THE HUMAN |
|---|---|
| Drones and AI now capture terrain and draft maps from point clouds automatically. Data collection that took a three-person crew takes one person and a flying camera. | The boundary decision stays human and licensed: weighing a 1920s deed against a fence line, testifying when neighbors disagree, signing your name to the line. Software measures; the surveyor decides and answers for it. |

⚠ **The road to the license is measured in years — education, supervised experience and multiple state exams. And your signature carries liability: a wrong line is a lawsuit with your name spelled correctly on it.**

## THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

| THE JOB IS | THE JOB IS NOT |
|---|---|
| ✓ Half field, half office — the balance keeps it fresh for decades<br>✓ A licensed profession with real scarcity and respect<br>✓ Every day starts outdoors somewhere different | ✗ Field years in brush, heat and traffic come before the stamp<br>✗ The license timeline cannot be hustled<br>✗ Precision pressure: your errors become other people's lawsuits |

Good fit? A precise, outdoors-loving puzzle solver who enjoys history, math and law-adjacent thinking — and plays the long game calmly.
Bad fit? You want licensed pay by next spring, or you hate documentation and detail work.

## THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

| DOOR A — SURVEYING DEGREE ROUTE | DOOR B — FIELD TECHNICIAN CLIMB |
|---|---|

| | |
|---|---|
| The direct route: a bachelor's (or state-approved associate path) in surveying/geomatics, then supervised experience and the state licensing exams — fundamentals first, professional licensure after the required years under a licensed surveyor. | Start as a survey technician or rod person with no degree: run instruments, learn from a crew chief, study alongside, and use your state's experience-based path where one exists. Slower to the stamp, but you earn from month one. |

Smart move: Learn drone mapping and point-cloud processing while you do field time. The technician who hands the licensed surveyor finished, checked data is the one who gets sponsored, promoted and remembered.
Where you land after: Licensed professional surveyor — then your own firm, where the stamp itself becomes the business.

## YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| CHOOSE YOUR | GET HIRED | BUILD THE | PASS THE | COMPLETE SUPERVISED | PASS THE |

### STEP 1 — Choose your license path on paper

FREE · 2 WEEKS

- Read your state board's exact requirements: education options, experience years, exam sequence.
- Decide degree route or technician route with the real timeline written down, not wished down.

### STEP 2 — Get hired onto a crew

PAID · MONTHS 1-3

- Survey firms hire field technicians for construction staking and boundary crews — field fitness and a clean driving record are the gates.
- Learn the instruments like a language: total station, GNSS, levels, data collectors.

### STEP 3 — Build the education block

$2,000-20,000 · YEARS 1-3

- Surveying coursework or degree progress alongside field work — math, geodesy, boundary law, CAD and GIS.
- Keep records of every project; your experience documentation feeds the license application later.

### STEP 4 — Pass the fundamentals exam

$300-600 · YEAR 2-3

- Sit the national fundamentals of surveying exam when your state allows — it certifies your base knowledge.
- Treat it seriously: it is the gate between technician and surveyor-in-training status in most states.

### STEP 5 — Complete supervised experience

PAID · YEARS 2-4

- Work under a licensed surveyor on boundary work specifically — construction staking alone does not build a boundary judgment.
- Study real boundary cases: deeds, plats, conflicting evidence and how your mentor resolves them.

### STEP 6 — Pass the professional exams, earn the stamp

$500-1,000 · YEAR 4

- Pass the professional surveying exam and your state's specific exam on its laws and standards.
- The license makes your signature the product — insure it, respect it, and price it accordingly.

## FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: read your state board's licensing requirements end to end and write your personal timeline.
- □ Days 1–30: apply for field technician roles; start learning instrument basics from any source available.
- □ Days 31–60: on a crew, learning field procedure, note-keeping and data discipline.
- □ Days 61–90: coursework chosen or started; your experience log begun and kept religiously.
- □ Day 90: in the pipeline — field hours accumulating, education moving, the stamp a dated goal instead of a vague one.

## NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **MEASURE TWICE. SIGN ONCE.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.